

The Devil WEARS KHADI

Bollywood doesn't like the evil that lurks in the hearts of politicians. *Raajneeti*'s powerful anti-hero shows why.

| By Kaveree Bamzai |

We generate the power and then hand over the button to them.' Why? It's one of the typically rousing statements in *Raajneeti* from Ajay Devgn, the Dalit kabaddi champion turned thorn-in-the-establishment flesh. We are the powerless and they are the ones who want to keep us that way. It's a struggle as old as the hills, or at least

as old as Raisina Hill, and in Prakash Jha's riveting film, it finds its ugliest depiction. No one is spared. Not the industrialist's fresh-faced daughter (Katrina Kaif) who is in love with one brother but married to the other as a business merger. Not the Dalit politician (Devgn) who believes "they survive because of us". And certainly not the outsider (Ranbir Kapoor), just back from Boston where he is a week away from submitting his thesis on

subtextual violence in 19th century Victorian poetry.

This is the politics that Jha's film explores, the unredeeming kind that brings out the *shaitan* (devil) in men. It brought out the *shaitan* in the Congress party as well, but it could have spared itself the bad press—there is little here that resembles the Gandhis, except for the widow who sweeps the election after the husband dies in a car bomb explosion. Bollywood has always been repelled by politicians, unless they look like the babalog who try to look like Rahul Gandhi—witness Abhishek Bachchan's Cambridge-educated, condom-supporting do-gooder in *Paa*. When confronted by portly bellies and pudgy heads bearing Nehru topis, they prefer to stuff clichés down their throats about *samaj* and *seva*. Young people are seen as the new hope, who will march into the Vidhan Sabha as in *Yuva* or take the high road of justice in *Sarkar Raj*. Very rarely are they, espe-

RAAJNEETI

"Some people think politics is like a public transport bus. Just signal with your hand and it will stop."

Arjun Rampal,
heir apparent, to an MLA candidate

RANBIR KAPOOR PLAYS SAMAR, PART ARJUNA, PART MICHAEL CORLEONE